The Noble Sūtra Called Taking Back Vitality

Āryaojaḥpratyaṅgiraṇasūtra · Toh 967 · Derge Kangyur
འཕགས་པ་མདངས་ཕྱིར་འཕགས་པ་ཞེས་བྱ་བའི་མདོ།

The Noble Sūtra Called Taking Back Vitality, known in Sanskrit as the Ārya Ojaḥpratyaṃgiraṇa Sūtra and in Tibetan as Pakpa Dang Chirtrokpa Zhejawé Do, is a short protective scripture centered on a spell for safeguarding a person's life force. Set at Śrāvastī, it opens with the Buddha urging the venerable Ānanda to take up, hold, read, and fully master the vidyā-mantra of Taking Back Vitality. He promises that anyone who does so will not have their vitality stolen, and that even if it is stolen, it will be fully restored. The Buddha then recites the mantra itself, so the work functions chiefly as a dhāraṇī text, a scripture whose value lies in the preservation and recitation of a potent formula. It is Toh 967 in the Kangyur, where it belongs among the collected dhāraṇīs and protective spells.

In the language of India: ārya ojaḥpratyaṃgiraṇa sūtra
In the language of Tibet: The Noble Sūtra Called Taking Back Vitality.

Homage to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One was dwelling at Śrāvastī. Then the Blessed One said to the venerable Ānanda, "Ānanda, take up the vidyā-mantra of Taking Back Vitality! Grasp it, read it, and master it completely! Ānanda, if anyone holds, teaches, reads, or completely masters the vidyā-mantra of Taking Back Vitality, their vitality will not be stolen and will not come to be stolen. Even if it is stolen, it will be fully restored again."

Then, at that time, the Blessed One spoke these bases of secret mantra:

tadyathā phile philame philumeṃge philumati valgumati sāravati kṣiravati kurumāti utavalani gauri gandhari cauri caṇḍali sture stuvare indramālini jalani sovāketrikṣoṣane sāgare mahāsāgare puruce purucure sanemane davaphe dadampaphe hulu hulu svāhā

When this vidyā-mantra was spoken, this great trichiliocosmic world system shook, shook strongly, and shook strongly everywhere. It quaked, quaked strongly, and quaked strongly everywhere. The yakṣas, too, sat weeping and letting out great cries and loud wails: "Alas, what suffering! Alas, we are wretched!"

"I, the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Śākyamuni, by the truth and the true words with which I have spoken this vidyā-mantra of Taking Back Vitality, by that truth and those true words I shall protect, until well-being is restored. I shall seize that vitality. I shall take it back. I shall bring it fully about.

"If someone is seized by a yakṣa, or seized by a human or a nonhuman, then at that time, at that hour, at that very moment, the vitality is reclaimed. It is not stolen again. It enters back in.

"If one who has stolen it does not give it back, but stays where he is without withdrawing, and still wishes to harm or wishes to steal, he will have displeased the Blessed One, the Tathāgata Śākyamuni, together with his assembly of śrāvakas."

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, the venerable Ānanda rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One had said.

This completes the Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra Called Taking Back Vitality.

Translator's Notes

• The passage after the mantra is terse, and its subjects are left unstated. The lines rendered "the vitality is reclaimed. It is not stolen again. It enters back in" literally read "vitality is seized; it is not seized back; it enters." They are taken here as describing how the vitality is restored to the afflicted person. Likewise, the conditional about the one who "does not give it back" contains a double negative ("does not do taking and not giving back"). It is taken to refer to a spirit who withholds stolen vitality. "Without withdrawing" renders rnam par mi 'jig, literally "does not disintegrate or disperse," and "harm" renders 'joms pa, literally "destroy." All of these readings are interpretive.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.